

The machinations of teenage boys and other adolescent problems:

Authors Note:

TMTBOAP is a passion project of mine that I have been working on for a while now. Hopefully, once it's done, it'll be my first-ever book. I've written short stories before, but I've always wanted the challenge of doing something at a much slower pace. My friend told me about this competition, and I was interested in both sharing my work with others and receiving feedback from those passionate about writing. This preview includes a prologue central to the story, chapters 1 to set the scene, and chapter 10. The story is meant to be uncomfortable; I wanted to try and portray the experience of a teenager (uncomfortable and often isolating.) specifically an Egyptian teenager. I hope you enjoy this very small preview of what I hope will be a 2-book project one day.

Prologue:

The officer sat down at the end of the couch. He wasn't dressed up; he didn't find it fancy enough of an occasion, I guess. No, no, he wore worn-out jeans and a shirt. Had I seen him in the streets I'd never have known he was anything more than a normal citizen. I would be offended by this had I not been spending most of my energy gluing myself to my seat...

A few minutes ago, I was waking up to my alarm and getting dressed for a guitar lesson. I've been attending them steadily for 2 months now. That was when my brother knocked carefully on my door.

"Layal..."

Nothing was explained to me. All I knew was something bad was happening and I might be late for my lesson. Safe to say I underestimated things ever so slightly. Going down the stairs I could hear the strange man my brother warned me about talking to both my parents. The more steps I took, the clearer the view was.

My mother sat on the far end of our dinner table, she looked tenser than usual. She had her chair turned towards the 2 men, my father, and the officer, who sat down opposite of each other on either of two small couches my mom had picked out when we moved in a year ago. My father's eyes spotted me at the bottom of the stairwell, on some occasions he faced me with a smile, today he instead chose to drift his eyes back to the strange man in our home, as if even his eyes were ashamed to look at me for too long.

I moved slowly towards them; I wish I didn't. I should've opened the front door then and ran. When I was close enough for my father to understand I planned to sit beside him, he got up. He went to go sit next to my mother instead.

For all he said, the strange man, who explained to me he was an officer, at least had the decency to be softer when speaking to me. It's not often I think that men of his station are told to go accuse 13-year-olds of federal crimes. I also had the decency to stay very quiet. It's not often someone accuses you of a federal crime as a 13-year-old.

"...Mabaheth. -"

I'd normally have cried by now if it were just my parents scolding me normally.

".... We've found a lot of evidence- "

My mother was crying, I was the one having my life ruined, and she was the one crying. I couldn't even bring myself to cry.

The man continues talking and my eyes drift toward my father. He still refuses to look at me. His eyes are red, I wonder if he wants to cry like my mom. The man does not shut up in the background.

I...didn't do any of this.

...and no one here is going to listen to me.

And then it began in my head. Quiet at first but growing louder and louder as the man continues speaking and my mom continues crying.

Kill yourself.

That disgusting voice always calling out in the corner of my mind.

Kill yourself.

and it's taking every part of me to not do what it says today.

The strange and terrible man continues talking and talking until at some point he asked for my parents to let him speak to me in private. I don't know what he said, it's been hard to listen.

My parents do as he said, they're not in any position to oppose this stranger in any way now. If they were, they would've given me a chance to explain that half of what the man said wasn't even true.

The man goes to speak first but the dam breaks before he can get a word out. Forgive me dignity I know you hate crying in front of people, but lord knows I'm only 13, everyone keeps forgetting that.

"they're going to kill me," I quietly repeated amidst tears.

They could. They might. They probably will.

He is saying something about a waiver he made my dad sign in the background. Something about swearing to keep me safe. I can't hear him that well over the

sound of me still crying over how they're going to kill me. Maybe when I'm dead the officer can go hang that waiver on my grave, see how well it helped. Maybe he'll live with the guilt of killing a 13-year-old, but I don't think the officers here can even feel guilt at all.

Chapter 1: The hallway-bell

“LAYAL!” The girl behind me screams amidst class.

“I’ve been calling you for like 5 minutes, what’s wrong with you.” But before I could get a word in, she cuts me off-

“Did you solve the last section yet?”

I turn my head away from her and back to my empty notebook and let out a quiet “No.” in response. It must have been loud enough for her to hear though since she didn’t speak to me again.

Every ring of the bell in the hallway startles me as we sit in class. It never rings on time, I never even understood why we had them there. No one else is affected by the bell’s incessant screeches every hour of the day other than me. Even the students who moved here after me have all grown accustomed to it and the teachers continue their explanations unfazed.

Occasionally new teachers look down at us confused when it rings. Some of them will roll up their sleeves and stare at their watches alternating between the watch face and us students until someone shouts, “it’s off” and they continue whatever mundane topic they had been rambling about before they had been interrupted.

My desk-mate nudges me ever so slightly while grabbing a new notebook from her bag. She apologizes on her way back up and I leave my school-bell trance to nod my head ever so slightly in her direction, letting her know it’s okay.

I pick up the pen next to my notebook and drift my eyes to her notebook in hopes of knowing what we should all do now. My attempt at a sly peek, however, fails and she turns her head to me and asks me if I need anything. My obliviousness to the task at hand confuses her.

She throws a slight joking tease my way about how she thought I was supposed to be the “smart girl in class” then tells me which paper we were working on now. While I’m sure she meant her comment in a light-hearted way, I couldn’t help but feel slightly stung by the words. Two months into this year and it feels like once again my place has been cemented.

I wonder if I’ll ever be anything other than the so-called “smart girl”.

The girl is of course unaware of the thoughts in my head and turns back to her notebook with a smile on her face.

I try to put a smile on my face while going back to my notes as well, but it feels crooked and uncomfortable. I drop the smile and go back to my characteristic blank slate expression.

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Someone taps me on my shoulder, and I raise my head off the desk. Some hazy words are scribbled on the board and students are loudly rushing out the door... a pair of disembodied legs in my peripheral. The legs move close, and I hear them say, “You going downstairs?”

It takes a bit for me to gather that I am not in fact talking to a random pair of legs but instead Leen. I reach my hand out to the phone I had placed face down in front of me. “11:30”

I put my hand in my bag and grab the little blue lid box I’d packed this morning. The box is translucent, revealing a random assortment of quick-to-pack snacks and a badly put-together sandwich. I placed it down on my desk while I regained consciousness for a bit.

“Are you okay?” she asks.

“Yea, yea, I’m good,”

A smile finally broke through her worried expression. I hope she doesn’t ask any more questions...

I hadn’t slept in 30-something hours. I don’t want her to be worried about me though, Leen was one of the only friends I’d made in the past 3 years in this school. She’s a kind person, she’ll start asking questions. She doesn’t need to put more energy into me for now.

I start heading out of the class then stop. I look back to see why Leen isn’t following, she looks back at me holding my little lunchbox.

“There’s something you’re not telling me.” She says straight-faced.

I thought I got away with it.

“Just, really sleepy today I guess.”

She looks at the box, looks at me, and decides not to press the issue further.

We walk down the stairs together, she tells me about the book she'd been reading, then a conversation with a friend, then a video she saw yesterday all at the same time. I loved her energy; she was a nice contrast to the dullness of life.

We made it to the yard, 2 soccer fields beside each other surrounded by a large net. Behind the net, benches were nailed down to the pavement. A few tables and a cafeteria sat to the right of the fields. I never liked to sit there though; it was always too crowded.

Leen and I were different on many fronts. She was more optimistic, she had her own problems, yes, but she always tried to be happy about everything. She was also more sociable, throughout the whole break people would greet her and she'd greet them back, she was in her element when with people.

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By the time we get to our fifth lap around the fields, the Physical Ed. teachers begin blowing the whistles they had hanging around their necks. Those who choose to not blow their whistles opt to shout at the students instead.

They always like to drag us upstairs 10 minutes earlier than the break ends. You'd think they'd do that so the stairs wouldn't be too crowded, but still the students

flood through, bumping into each other the entire way up. I hated going up those stairs with everyone but at least it meant I'd be leaving in a few more hours.

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The bell rang and I jumped ever so slightly in my seat again.

“Every damn time...”

The teacher's voice droned on and on in the background. Even though I sat in the front, he stopped trying to wake me up. I reach my hand for the phone I left lying face down on my desk and check the time.

The screen's light is dim but amongst the cracks on my screen a white 1:58 contrasts against the dark background. I stare at my screen, obsessively tapping it until the screen changes to that of my 2:00 alarm.

The phone's body vibrates for a second, but I quickly turn it off before my Arabic teacher notices and takes the phone away.

I keep the little box full of pills in the left-side breast pocket of my school's blazer. The box is a bit bigger than I wish it was but so is the blazer, so the box is not too apparent.

I take the pink pill tab section I'd cutout out of the bottom right section and quietly pop out one of the little pink discs into my hand. The taste is chalky and lingering, but I know that it'll eventually pass.

Chapter 10: Lover's Insomnia

The outline of a bright red 2:00 shone from my alarm and onto my face. All I could think about was him. His brown eyes, his crooked nose, his wavy hair. I couldn't help but think what his hair would feel like in my hands.

I paused the thought. I can't keep ending up like this. The room continued to alternate between hot and cold; I continued to shift my position in my bed every few minutes, doing my best to ignore the fantasies my mind had been pushing on me for the past hour. I held onto my pillow tightly for a while, eventually letting go when my I began wondering what it would be like if he took the pillow's place.

A cold sweat passes through my body every now and then as it overheats from certain... thoughts passing through my mind. I can't help it, if I could I would make all this stop. It's not like I enjoy the guilt I'm left with afterward. My cheeks burn with his voice in my head whispering sweet nothings to me as we fall asleep beside each other. I bury my head in my pillow knowing that some part of me wishes that was his chest instead.

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20 minutes go by, and my sleepless state remains unchanged. Eventually, my hand reached for my phone. A thought whizzes by in my head about exposure therapy or something, by now I know it's an excuse I'm giving myself to justify staring at his socials for the 3rd time this week. My fingers automatically put in the numbered code, 92766, and I unconsciously open his page.

He doesn't post much, but out of the few pictures he has posted there's one I particularly like. Faded light blue jeans and a white hoodie that drapes loosely around him. His hair was longer back by the end of winter when he had taken the photo. His clothes weren't the focus of the photo though. This was one of the first times I'd seen him with a smile that seemed so genuine.

I always found myself coming back to that photo, noticing new details every time. The way his eyes creased at the corners slightly, the way his hair moved in the wind, the way the faintest trace of dimples showed up in his cheeks when he did smile. He was cute but he didn't know he was cute, which made him even cuter somehow. I liked him for him and that terrified me.

I did my best to ignore the multiple comments from girls at our school trying their best to indirectly flirt with him and get his attention. He's popular, he's desirable, he's handsome, I know all that... it still doesn't make me hate reading those comments any less though. All they do is serve as a reminder of how different our lives are. We were both living on parallel lines and no matter how much I wanted our lines to meet now, they never would.

All our conversations so far have been extremely short. And all of them always had something to do with our school subjects. I will admit I happily respond to anything he asks me, but I know that sentiment isn't shared on both sides. I'm sure if we hadn't met in a school setting, he would have never noticed me.

A lot of people seem to come into my life out of whatever necessity they currently have it seems. My relationship with most people is that of a 'quiet recluse who will help out with schoolwork if you ask nice enough'. That last part isn't even a necessity honestly. It's not like I do it out of the kindness of my heart, I'd love to say I do but honestly, I just want to have any thread to hold onto so that I stay out of people's bad sides. I don't need a repeat of...

Lemons stares at me from his side on my pillow. "Don't you stare at me with your judging little plushed face like that. You think I'm spiraling over nothing don't you" Lemons of course continues to stare, as any large Shiba Inu plush would. I pull Lemons into my arms and squish him lightly.

“He’s driving me insane.”

The alarm now says 4:00. Soon my family will be awake for Fajr, and with the last few moments of nighttime solitude I have, I drag my feet off the bed, pick up a new shirt and shorts from my closet, and go to the bathroom for a hot shower. I need to get back to my senses.

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My clothes drop onto the cold bathroom tiles, red-drop stains catch my eyes as I untie my hair bun. Suddenly the past week makes a lot more sense.

On particularly bad days, I like to imagine the heat of the shower as a warm embrace from a loved one or close friend. I try to focus my energy on the heat passing through my body instead of on the myriad of thoughts perpetually in my mind. Over the past few years, my doctor and I’s insistence on avoiding medications has led to me figuring out a lot of ways to handle different situations.

I sit down on the toilet waiting for my hair mask to set in with a towel off my shoulders, so I don't get cold. The box says I should let it sit for 10 minutes but I always do 15. The time passes, I wash out the mask, some of it goes into my eyes. That feels like a central part of the routine.

I mop the floor of the bathroom, making sure to get every spot of water I see, and dry myself down. My hair stays tied up in its specialized towel and I fold up a few tissues and place them between my legs until I can grab a pad from my room. I waddle my way awkwardly to my room, secure the pad, place all the necessary products in my hair, and pull it back to a Dutch braid the way Leen had taught me to keep it out of my way.

I accepted that I was in no way going to get some sleep tonight, so I sat down at my desk and opened my laptop. The laptop struggled slightly but I wasn't going to be able to get a new laptop anytime soon.

After a while, the sun makes its presence known even through my curtains. I push my chair back from my desk and head towards my bed, where I left my phone next to Lemons. I'd lost track of the time. The lock screen of my phone leaves me in slight shock as I stare at the large text at the top, 7:05. My eyes drag down to the notification waiting for me below the slightly concerning time.

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